the move, Netanyahu doubted he would have a majority. Their opposition effectively took the issue off the table.

The argument went public the following year. “It’s the stupidest thing I’ve ever heard,” Dagan told at audience at the Hebrew University in 2011, mere months after leaving his post. “It will be followed by a war with Iran.” He repeated the argument in several subsequent public appearances. In a 2012 interview on 60 Minutes, he warned that an airstrike would bring missiles raining down on Tel Aviv. “It will have a devastating impact on our ability to continue with our daily life. I think that Israel will be in a very serious situation for quite a time,” he said.

Dagan, a bald man built like a fireplug, would remain one of Netanyahu’s most persistent and colorful critics. A camera crew from Channel 2 sat with him in March 2015, while Netanyahu denounced the Iran deal in a controversial speech to Congress. At one point, when the prime minister was discussing Iran’s progress toward a bomb, Dagan could be seen muttering “bullshit”. Days later, he was the keynote speaker at the anti-Netanyahu election rally in Rabin Square. By then he was battling an advanced case of cancer; he had received a liver transplant in Belarus several years earlier.

Netanyahu ignored all of this in his eulogy. He recalled sitting with the former Mossad chief and laughing at “how daring and even rude his ideas were”. In interviews shortly before his death, though, Dagan offered a different recollection of his meetings with the prime minister. He liked to tell the “falafel story”. The notoriously indecisive Netanyahu would approve covert actions, then quickly change his mind, fearing the potential consequences. So instead of driving back to his apartment in Tel Aviv, after meeting Netanyahu, “I would go for falafel in Mahane Yehuda,” Dagan said, referring to a popular market near the prime minister’s office. He would eat, and wait for the inevitable phone call asking him to return. (For more complicated operations, which took longer to contemplate, he would drive out to Abu Ghosh, an Arab village west of Jerusalem that is famous for its hummus.) “I was never wrong,” he said. “He always called me back.”

He was even harsher in remarks published shortly after his death: Netanyahu was “the worst manager I know,” he said, a man who didn’t have the “balls” to approve daring moves.[10]